

DigiPick of the month

"The Male
Computer Zone"



Last month's
winner is

Manas Kumar
Gayatri Nagar
Rayagada 765001
Orissa

Participate and win next month
Information Technology
by Eric H. Glendinning & John
McEwan
Published by
Oxford University Press



WIN!

Send in your entry and you could win an exciting gift just by sharing an amusing picture with a tech angle to it. The picture should have been shot by you, and should not have been published anywhere earlier. E-mail your picture with the subject 'DigiPick' and your postal address **on or before the 20th of this month** to digipick@thinkdigit.com. One prize-winning picture will be published each month.

for no little confusion he created: his comments were taken to mean that Vista is so secure, it's possible to run it without an anti-virus. He was responding to questions about whether Vista will be more secure than XP, and Allchin, very irresponsibly, pronounced that his seven-year-old son runs a Vista PC without anti-virus protection. Bad boy, Allchin Jr.

Allchin said that his comments, if true, would decimate the software security market—that they had been taken out of context and misinterpreted.

Now what misguided moron misinterpreted them? Vista's anti-piracy measures have already been cracked. In August, a security researcher demonstrated live several ways to circumvent security features built into Vista. God knows, Vista isn't cracker-safe.

No, Mr Allchin, we don't need an apology—we love

our anti-viruses, thank you. Just tell junior to stop getting on the Net without a good firewall and anti-virus in place. And we'll tell you this: we'll probably upgrade anyway. *Build* an anti-virus into Vista for God's sake, if you can.

THE JOY OF GIVING

Passing The Parcel

Innovation on the Web is not dead by any measure. Christmas is approaching, and apart from being the season to Give, it can also be the season to Re-Give. At least that's what www.regiftable.com, a new Web site, thinks.

The general idea is that if you're 50 and you've received your 403rd tie as a gift (or even if it's your 491st, for that matter), you could gift it to someone else, making for that man's 254th tie. This saves time, money, and the

need to come up with gift ideas. You know what a pain that can be.

A non-profit called Money Management International (MMI), which does consumer education and financial counselling, came up with the site. Quoting a spokeswoman, "Whether or not you're a fan or a foe, re-gifting has become a phenomenon." A survey MMC did last year found that 40 per cent of the gifting population had saved money using this tacky approach to penny-pinching.

Some people at the Web site think it's a good idea, but not everyone does—imagine being re-gifted what you gifted! One woman at the site said her sister "thinks by putting a big bow on her re-gifts, no-one will know they have been re-gifted." Turns out she'd received the gift she had given her sister a year earlier.

We think it's one of those Web ideas that was just waiting for prime-time—one of those ideas that either fizzle out in a couple of weeks or catch on big-time.

TIME-PASS FOR THE RICH

Internet Addiction? We Don't Think So

People in super-rich countries seem hypochondriacs to us—all of them. Every now and then, you'll see something in the press about Internet Addiction, as though it were as serious as a brain

People Who Changed Computing

He Foresaw Y2K

The man behind the [Esc] key—which allowed one to terminate the current process—was



Bob Bemer

Bob Bemer. Of course, we use the key in different contexts now, and it might seem

insignificant: a key! However, it has been contemplated that without the functionality of "escape", it could have been impossible to agree on and accept ASCII as a standard! Yes, Bemer is often referred to as the father of the ASCII code, without which there would have been no e-mail, no WWW, no video games.

Bemer made several contributions to the field of computer science in general, many of them unrelated. With his own COMTRAN language, and Grace Hopper's (the creator of COBOL) FLOW-MATIC, he helped create the COBOL programming language—and it was Bemer who coined the name. Bemer was the first (in 1971) to identify and warn of the problem associated with using two digits instead of four to represent years, which was later termed, of course, the Y2K or millennium bug.

Other noted contributions include the first publication of the time-sharing concept. In 2003, Bemer received the IEEE Computer Pioneer Award. He died in 2004 of cancer.